

Who Pays and Who Decides: What the Numbers Hide

谁承担，谁决定：数字隐藏了什么

Theme: 社会问题、经济与公共生活 · New: 44 · Review: 18 · Planned cumulative progress: 44/6,127

English Story

The numbers **now** required a **room** of their own, and the **reality** they described was worse than the **practical** one. “The figure for the **circle** of payers is a **square** peg,” the **editor** wrote. “It does not fit at any **angle**.” The **observer** and the **adviser** had both signed the **headline**, and neither of them was willing to **defend** it in public.

The **ban** on new connections was a **severe violation** of the **fabric** of the old town. “A **defensive** policy with an **offensive punishment** is not **morality**,” the **adviser** said. “It is a **denial** dressed as a **bargain**.” A **harsh** winter, a **reluctant** council, and a **loyalty** to the old tariff had produced the whole crisis.

The **insert** in the **periodical** was an **invitation** to the public to **publicize** its own bills. “**Fame** is not the point,” the **editor** said. “A household that is penalized for using water is a fact, not a **headline**.” The **consultative** committee met in a church hall and played **chess** afterwards.

The **cruelty** of the numbers was their symmetry: the **circle** of payers and the **circle** of users were drawn in the same **square**. “A **cruel inference** is still an **inference**,” the **adviser** said. “You can **forbid** the word and you cannot **forbid** the arithmetic.”

The **betrayal** was in the timing. “We were told to **oversee** a process and not a war,” the **observer** wrote. “The **warfare** of two departments has produced a **diplomacy** of delays.” The **editor's denial** of the first draft was, in the end, correct.

The real issue came into the **room** at last: who draws the **circle**, and with what instrument. The air in the hall was cold, the water in the well was low, and the group had, for the first time, a long list and a short time. The order of the day was not an act of **hell** but a development we had to get through; the **inviting insert** in the **periodical** told us so. The **room**, the **square**, and the air in it were all part of the same period, and the **editor** asked us to **defend** the **headline** once more.

中文翻译

这些数字如今需要一间自己的房间，而它们所描述的现实比实际的那个更糟。“缴款者那个圆的数字是一根方钉，”编辑写道，“它在任何角度都嵌不进去。”观察者和顾问都在那则大标题上签了字，而两人都不愿公开为它辩护。

对新接入的禁令，是对老城构造的一处严重违反。“一项用攻击性惩罚来执行的防卫政策不是道德，”顾问说，“那是披着交易外衣的否认。”一个严酷的冬天、一个不情愿的议会，以及对旧费率的一种忠诚，造成了整场危机。

期刊里的那份插页，是邀请公众公开自己的账单。“名声不是重点，”编辑说，“一个因为用水而被处罚的家庭是一个事实，不是一条头条。”咨询委员会在一座教堂大厅里开会，会后下了一盘国际象棋。

这些数字的残酷在于它们的对称：缴款者的圆和使用者的圆画在同一个方框里。“残酷的推论仍然是推论，”顾问说，“你可以禁止那个词，却无法禁止算术。”

背叛在于时机。“我们被告知要监督一个流程，而不是一场战争，”观察者写道，“两个部门的交战产出了一套拖延的外交。”编辑对第一稿的否认，最终是对的。

真正的问题终于进了房间：谁来画这个圆，用什么工具画。大厅里的空气是冷的，井里的水是低的，而这个小组第一次有了一份长清单和一段短时间。当日的议程不是一桩地狱般的行为，而是一段我们必须走完的发展；期刊里那份邀请人的插页就是这么告诉我们的。这个房间、这个广场，以及其中的空气，都属于同一个时期，而编辑要求我们再为那则大标题辩护一次。

Core Vocabulary · 核心词汇

Word / Pronunciation	Context meaning / source example
now nau POS: adv	adv. 现在, 刚才, 目前; n. 现在; a. 现在的; conj. 由于 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. the momentary present; r. in the historical present; at this point in the narration of a series of past eve...
room ru:m POS: n	n. 房间, 空位, 场所; vi. 住宿, 居住; vt. 留宿 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. an area within a building enclosed by walls and floor and ceiling; n. space for movement; n. opportunity for...
require ri'kwaɪə POS: vt	vt. 需要, 命令, 要求; [法] 需要, 要求, 命令 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: v require as useful, just, or proper; v consider obligatory; request and expect; v make someone do something; v...
reality ri'æliti POS: n	n. 实在, 事实, 实体, 逼真; [法] 现实, 实在存在的事物, 实在性 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. the state of being actual or real; n. the state of the world as it really is rather than as you might want...
practical 'præktɪkl POS: a	a. 实际的, 现实的, 实用性的; [法] 事实上的, 实际上的, 接近...的 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: a. concerned with actual use or practice; s. having or put to a practical purpose or use
editor 'editə POS: n	n. 编者, 编辑, 主笔, 编辑器, 编辑装置; [计] 编辑器 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. a person responsible for the editorial aspects of publication; the person who determines the final content...
hell hel POS: n	n. 地狱, 邪恶势力, 苦境, 阴间, 毁坏, 训斥; vi. 狂饮, 飞驰 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. any place of pain and turmoil; ; n. a cause of difficulty and suffering; n. (Christianity) the abode of Sata...
circle 'sɜ:kl POS: n	n. 圆周, 社交圈, 循环, 范围; vt. 围着, 环绕; vi. 盘旋, 循环 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. ellipse in which the two axes are of equal length; a plane curve generated by one point moving at a consta...
defend di'fend POS: vt	vt. 防护, 辩护, 防卫; [法] 作...的辩护律师, 辩护, 为...答辩 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: v. argue or speak in defense of; v. be on the defensive; act against an attack; v. protect against a challenge...
square skweə POS: n	n. 正方形, 街区, 广场, 平方, 直角尺; a. 正方形的, 正直的, 公正的, 平方的, 方正的, 结清的; adv. 成直角地, 对... Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. (geometry) a plane rectangle with four equal sides and four right angles; a four-sided regular polygon; n. ...
severe si'viə POS: a	a. 严格的, 尖锐的, 严肃的, 严重的, 严厉的, 朴素的; [法] 严厉的, 苛刻的, 严重的 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: s. intensely or extremely bad or unpleasant in degree or quality; s. unsparing and uncompromising in disciplin...
angle 'æŋgl POS: n	n. 角, 角度, 角落; vi. 钓鱼, 谋取, 博取, 斜向移动, 转变角度; vt. 使转动角度, 在...钓鱼, 获取 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. the space between two lines or planes that intersect; the inclination of one line to another; measured in...
observer əb'zə:və POS: n	n. 观察者, 遵守者, 观察员; [法] 观察者, 观察员, 监场员 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. an expert who observes and comments on something
adviser əd'vaɪzə POS: n	n. 顾问, 劝告者, 指导教师; [法] 顾问, 劝告者 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. an expert who gives advice
fabric 'fæbrɪk POS: n	n. 织物, 布, 结构, 构造, 建筑物; [经] 组织, 建筑物, 工厂 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. artifact made by weaving or felting or knitting or crocheting natural or synthetic fibers
ban bæn POS: n	n. 禁令; vt. 禁止, 取缔 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. 100 bani equal 1 leu in Moldova; n. 100 bani equal 1 leu in Romania; n. an official prohibition or edict aga...
violation ,vaɪə'leɪʃən POS: n	n. 违反, 违背, 妨碍; [法] 违犯, 违背, 违反 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. an act that disregards an agreement or a right
defensive di'fensɪv POS: a	a. 防卫的, 防备用的, 自卫的; n. 守势, 防卫姿势, 防卫物 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. an attitude of defensiveness (especially in the phrase `on the defensive'); a. intended or appropriate for...
punishment 'pʌnɪʃmənt POS: n	n. 处罚, 刑罚, 惩罚; [法] 罚, 处罚, 刑罚 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. the act of punishing
offensive ə'fensɪv POS: a	a. 令人不快的, 侮辱的, 攻击性的; [法] 攻击的, 进攻的, 冒犯的 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: s. violating or tending to violate or offend against; a. for the purpose of attack rather than defense; a. caus...

Word / Pronunciation	Context meaning / source example
invitation ˌɪnvɪ'teɪʃən POS: n	n. 邀请, 请柬, 引诱; [经] 邀请, 招待, 吸引 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. a request (spoken or written) to participate or be present or take part in something; n. a tempting allurem...
headline 'hedlaɪn POS: n	n. 大标题, 新闻摘要; vt. 为...做标题, 写标题 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. the heading or caption of a newspaper article; v. publicize widely or highly, as if with a headline; v. prov...
harsh hɑːʃ POS: a	a. 粗糙的, 刺耳的, 严厉的; [法] 粗糙的, 严厉的, 苛刻的 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: s. unpleasantly stern; s. disagreeable to the senses; s. unkind or cruel or uncivil; s. severe
reluctant rɪ'lʌktənt POS: a	a. 不情愿的, 勉强的; [法] 不愿的, 勉强的, 难以处理的 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: s. disinclined to become involved; s. not eager
loyalty 'lɔɪəlti POS: n	n. 忠贞, 忠诚, 忠实; [法] 忠诚, 忠心 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. the quality of being loyal; n. feelings of allegiance
insert ɪn'sɜ:t POS: n	n. 插入物; vt. 插入, 把(人造卫星)射入(轨道), 添写; vi. 附着; [计] 插入 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. a folded section placed between the leaves of another publication; n. an artifact that is inserted or is to...
oversee ˌəʊvə'siː POS: vt	vt. 向下看, 了望, 监督, 偷看到; [法] 监察, 监督, 俯瞰 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: v. watch and direct
cruel 'kruːəl POS: a	a. 残酷的, 令人极痛苦的; [法] 残忍的, 残酷的 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: s (of persons or their actions) able or disposed to inflict pain or suffering
fame feɪm POS: n	n. 名望, 名声, 传说 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. the state or quality of being widely honored and acclaimed; n. favorable public reputation
forbid fə'bid POS: vt	vt. 禁止, 不准, 妨碍; [法] 不许, 禁止, 阻止 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: v. command against
morality mə'reælɪti POS: n	n. 道德, 教训, 品行; [法] 道德, 道义 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. concern with the distinction between good and evil or right and wrong; right or good conduct
denial dɪ'naɪəl POS: n	n. 否认; [法] 否定, 否认, 拒绝接受 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. the act of refusing to comply (as with a request); n. the act of asserting that something alleged is not tr...
bargain 'bɑːɡɪn POS: n	n. 交易, 买卖协定, 特价商品; v. 讲价, 交易 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. an agreement between parties (usually arrived at after discussion) fixing obligations of each; n. an advant...
warfare 'wɔːfeə POS: n	n. 战争, 战斗, 交战, 斗争, 竞争; [法] 战事, 作战, 交战 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n the waging of armed conflict against an enemy; n an active struggle between competing entities
diplomacy dɪ'pləʊməsi POS: n	n. 外交, 外交手腕, 交际手段; [法] 外交, 外交手腕, 权谋 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. negotiation between nations
cruelty 'kruːəlti POS: n	n. 残酷, 野蛮, 残酷行为; [法] 残酷, 残忍, 虐待 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. a cruel act; a deliberate infliction of pain and suffering; n. feelings of extreme heartlessness; n. the qua...
inference ɪn'fɜːrəns POS: n	n. 推论; [法] 推论, 推理, 推断 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. the reasoning involved in drawing a conclusion or making a logical judgment on the basis of circumstantial...
consultative kən'sʌltətɪv POS: a	a. 商议的, 协议的, 咨询的; [法] 咨询的, 商议的, 协议的 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: s giving advice
chess tʃes POS: n	n. 国际象棋; [建] 雀麦 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. weedy annual native to Europe but widely distributed as a weed especially in wheat; n. a board game for two...
betrayal bɪ'treɪəl POS: n	n. 背叛, 辜负; [法] 背叛, 通敌, 背信 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. the quality of aiding an enemy
publicize 'pʌblɪsaɪz POS: vt	vt. 宣传 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: v. make public
inviting ɪn'vaɪtɪŋ POS: a	a. 引人动心的, 有魅力的; [法] 诱惑人的, 动人心的 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: a. attractive and tempting
periodical ˌpɪərɪ'bdɪkl POS: n	n. 期刊; a. 定期出版的, (有关)期刊的, 间歇(性的), 周期的, 定期的 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: n. a publication that appears at fixed intervals

Word / Pronunciation	Context meaning / source example
penalize 'pi:nəlaiz POS: vt	vt. 处刑, 对...处罚(刑), 使不利; [法] 处罚, 对...处以刑事惩罚 Collocation: — (not independently sourced) Example: v impose a penalty on; inflict punishment on